HELPING FIELD SERVICE ORGANIZATIONS AUTOMATE PROCESSES AND SOLVE KEY PAIN POINTS

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and Solve Key Pain Points

An industry that's expected to bring in $5.59 billion in annual sales by 2023, the field service management sector is ripe for a technology overhaul that can help it more efficiently manage critical services, maximize resources and create higher levels of customer satisfaction.

Orchestrating a team of mobile field service technicians, administering work order assignments, handling preventative maintenance and managing inventory all require an approach that transcends phone calls, emails, spreadsheets and disparate technology systems. Yet, these are the exact methods that many field service organizations and manufacturers use when managing their operations.

They're also using technology, with the tools of choice being field service management programs that handle dispatching, work order assignments and scheduling. Very few field service companies or manufacturers that include service organizations rely on unified, cloud-based solutions that integrate these and other functions onto a single platform.

Once in place, a unified solution can help companies more efficiently manage the selling/servicing of equipment, technician routing/dispatching, inventory tracking, while monitoring equipment service repair history, among other functions. In this white paper, we explore the industry's biggest challenges and show how a unified, cloud platform can streamline operations, automate processes and get all stakeholders working from the same playbook.

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Chapter **1**

IDENTIFYING THE DISCONNECTS

On track to reach $5.59 billion in annual sales by 2023 (up from $1.78 billion in 2016), the global field service management sector is realizing a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 16.6%, according to MRFR Analysis and Stratistics Market Research Company. To run their businesses, most of these field service organizations rely on software systems that date as far back as 2000, which manage functions like accounting, invoicing, scheduling and dispatch, inventory, and barcoding.

Larger entities in the sector typically have enterprise resource planning (ERP) systems, but those solutions are usually standalone and don't integrate with other applications. This approach has left many companies with a hodgepodge of disparate systems that don't "talk" to one another. "Many of them use a mix of QuickBooks for accounting, homegrown systems, Excel spreadsheets and separate field service management systems for scheduling, dispatching and invoicing," said Robert Keuroglian, Founder, President and CEO at Sentrien Systems, Inc. "Even with that technology in place, most of the work is highly manual by nature."

To schedule and dispatch technicians, for example, a company will use Excel spreadsheets and Google Maps to select the best possible routes and then decide which resources to allocate to specific customer sites on any given day. Based on the number of support tickets in the queue, these decisions are usually made by a scheduler or dispatcher who analyzes the nature of the work, the skill set required and availability of labor.

Chapter **2**

LOGISTICS: MANAGING THE FINE POINTS

To achieve that goal, organizations must be able to answer questions like: How are we managing the supply chain process? Do we have the right inventory on our trucks? Are we out of stock on any items? How many times does a driver have to purchase an item at retail that we unknowingly had in our warehouse?

For parts management, most field service companies and manufacturers use a combination of disparate applications and off-line manual processes. Locally installed software may typically handle the needs of the corporate users and the service aspect of the business, but it's not integrated with the rest of the company in a way that "connects" remote technicians. It also doesn't allow workers to document their activity while out in the field. Without a direct connection to field activities, this knowledge gap directly impacts the field service organization's Vice President of Service, who is charged with providing very high levels of customer service and support.

"This is an industry where it is vital to reduce the amount of time required to resolve a work order ticket, while maintaining confidence that your technician will leave a job site after the first visit with a customer's equipment operating at peak efficiency," said Keuroglian. "It's all about lowering the odds of having to make a return trip while increasing the technician's productivity when he or she is working at the customer's site."

The latter can quickly lead to cost overruns because the technician probably didn't get the same, agreed-upon vendor price when buying it ad hoc at retail. The same tech also had to spend time and waste fuel running around, trying to track down the part when he or she could have been onsite, handling the repair or routine service call.

These and other disconnects surface when firms are working with two different data sets, one of which lies in an ERP and the other in a field service management solution. The former manages labor costs, time management and payroll timecard systems, while the latter focuses primarily on dispatch and work order management.

"When those two systems aren't talking to one another, measuring profitability by job, labor utilization by technician and overall customer satisfaction is nearly impossible."

— **Robert Keuroglian,** Founder, President and CEO, Sentrien Systems, Inc.

Chapter **3**

ONE VERSION OF THE TRUTH: GETTING CONTROLLERS AND VPs OF SERVICE ON THE SAME PAGE

When Keuroglian walks into a field service company, his end goal is always the same: to get the firm's Vice President of Service and its Controller working from the same playbook and talking about the value of a one-stop-shop technology approach. With experience in field service, project management, supply chain, accounting and finance, Keuroglian said Sentrien stands a pretty good chance of achieving that goal. That's because Oracle NetSuite unified with Sentrien Field Service allows the Vice President of Service to automate:

- Fixed Bid versus Time and Material Work Orders
- No Charge Warranty Service Trips
- Schedule and Dispatch
- Automated Route Management
- Work Order Management
- Truck Stock/Inventory Control
- Preventative Maintenance
- Contract Management
- Customer Asset History
- Real-Time Technician Status

And the CFO or Controller to streamline:

- Forecast/Demand Planning
- Manufacturing/Supply Chain
- Project Management
- Job Profitability
- Labor/Resource Utilization
- Revenue Recognition/ASC 606
- Vendor Management
- Customer/Vendor Portal
- Stakeholder Reporting and Analysis

By bringing these critical business functions together onto a single platform, Sentrien supports a streamlined, automated model in an industry that's long relied on manual and disparate solutions. "We deliver state-of-the-art field service directly within NetSuite," said Keuroglian, "and give companies a platform that supports growth, efficiency and profitability."

Chapter **4**

EQUIPMENT LIFECYCLE MANAGEMENT: IMPROVING YOUR CUSTOMER'S EQUIPMENT ROI

"In a growing competitive industry, the field service organization that provides their customer with an ability to track the lifecycles of equipment will be the organization that is sought after. Our customers know exactly how many service tickets have been generated on any specific piece of equipment. That knowledge helps the field service provider to establish preventative maintenance cycles that keep their customers' investments operational."

— **Robert Keuroglian,** Founder, President and CEO, Sentrien Systems, Inc.

Equipment that is eight years old and experiencing repeated breakdowns, for example, is probably ready for replacement—versus more repairs. Using Sentrien Field Service, anyone can quickly locate specific repairs made to any piece of equipment, ascertain how much was spent on those repairs and determine a preventative maintenance schedule to maximize a total return on investment (ROI).

With this data at their fingertips, companies that are operating in regulated industries can easily prove that their equipment—and the associated repairs, service and maintenance—is compliant. For example, vital infrastructure found in the health care sector, or power generation equipment found in senior assisted living facilities, must have documentation to support the frequency of preventative maintenance, service and repair. Using Sentrien Field Service, that company can easily document all of its activity over time and provide detailed service history to its customers upon request. This, in turn, helps the field service organization manage its exposure to external events (i.e., investigations or lawsuits) while also improving customer relations by maximizing equipment uptime.

Using Industrial Internet of Things (IIoT) devices and Sentrien Field Service Management, the same companies can extract even more value from NetSuite. Organizations that service equipment, for example, rely heavily on optimal equipment utilization with maximum uptime. With IIoT, they can effectively transform their field operations from traditional sales/service-based models to those that are focused on positive outcomes and proactive maintenance.

"By combining Oracle NetSuite and Sentrien Field Service with external IIoT devices, companies can capture, evaluate and report against potential product failure prior to conditional system degradation."

— **Robert Keuroglian,** Founder, President and CEO, Sentrien Systems, Inc.

CASE STUDY

"In the company's prior system, the dispatcher would just put all the jobs on the board even if the first phase of the job was incomplete. That caused a lot of problems in terms of dispatching the wrong people at the wrong time to go look at the job site, which wasn't even ready for a proper inspection."

— **Robert Keuroglian,** Founder, President and CEO, Sentrien Systems, Inc.

From Disparate Systems to a Unified Cloud Platform

When one manufacturer of industrial-grade compactors or "balers" realized that the disconnect between its field service solution and accounting software was creating major inefficiencies across its organization, it decided to do something about it. The company's biggest pain points included double data entry, limited correlation between work order tickets and job locations, and a rudimentary mobile application that didn't allow field technicians to communicate in real-time with the headquarters.

The company needed a better method for tracking its fixed-bid, versus time and material work orders, and effectively managing warranty tracking. Managing crews out on the road was arduous and became even more challenging when multiple crews were being managed on the same work order. Prioritization of jobs was also important. For example, if a quality control assessment had to be done first, followed by the actual work, then the sequencing of those tasks had to correlate with the technicians routing and scheduling.

These and other challenges made field service management costly and time-consuming for the baler manufacturer, which implemented NetSuite with Sentrien Field Service earlier this year. The unified solution now automatically tracks jobs, decrements inventory (even when a job is still in process) and handles real-time inventory management out in the field—something the organization wasn't doing with its previous solution.

“Service trucks typically carry as much as $30,000-$40,000 in equipment and parts,” said Keuroglian. “When parts are taken off a truck, the technician can now record that on a tablet and the system will decrement inventory immediately from being ‘available’ to being ‘reserved.’ Then, as the work order closes out, that inventory is taken out of the reservation site and automatically charged as a cost of goods sold.”

Generated in NetSuite, work orders are released and assigned to technicians who are immediately notified about the assignment. Using a mobile tablet, technicians accept their work and then automatically track their assignments throughout the life of the project. For example, the system automatically documents the worker’s arrival time, any “pauses” in the work (e.g., for multi-day projects) and the project completion time.

The unified platform also tracks parts usage, expense reports, employee reimbursements (for parts that had to be purchased at retail) and other key points. Using a mobile tablet, the technician simply records notes about the job and captures the clients’ approval using an electronic signature.

Finally, the system also manages warranty tracking. Tagged to specific balers or tasks (depending on the company’s choice), the warranty management feature analyzes the length of the warranty period and enables a streamlined repair process across different technicians. An effective tool for return trip management, the system will zero out the billing of invoices automatically when it sees that the same, in-warranty equipment has been worked on by multiple technicians within a prescribed warranty period.

By automating previously manual functions like routing, scheduling and dispatching, NetSuite and Sentrien Field Service have created a more streamlined, predictable and manageable enterprise for the baler manufacturer.

By taking the guesswork out of the work order process, inventory, field work and warranty management, this manufacturer can now focus on what it does best: creating quality, industrial-grade balers for its eco-conscious customers.

ABOUT SENTRIEN SYSTEMS

"Our core mission is to improve our customers' cloud adoption strategy and data management. We sit at the intersection of technology, business process and solution engineering, and offer our own native NetSuite Field Service solution that works within—and isn't external to—the NetSuite platform."

— **Robert Keuroglian,** Founder, President and CEO, Sentrien Systems, Inc.

Solving the Field Service Industry's Biggest Challenges

A national Solution Provider and Software Development Network Partner for NetSuite, Sentrien brings decades of business acumen and hundreds of software implementation experiences to the table when working with field service organizations.

Using a SuiteSuccess model, Sentrien onboards new customers the same way that NetSuite does via its own SuiteSuccess approach. "We start each relationship with a 1:1 client awareness session, which allows us to understand the motivation and vision of each client," said Keuroglian, "regardless of size or complexity."

As part of that process, Sentrien breaks the field service industry down into the specific challenges that each company is facing and then addresses those issues using a unified technology approach that far surpasses the fragmented options that many companies have been using up until now.

"We look at what's beneficial to that specific company and why it makes sense to improve its IT environment and software infrastructure on NetSuite," Keuroglian said. "This is where NetSuite really stands out in its ability to customize workflows that automate the field service environment in a world where other solutions fall short."

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